

Title: नज़र ना लगे [Nazar na Lage; may no evil eye/gaze get you]¹: An Introduction to the History of Visual Cultures of India

Description:

How does the visual make us think, re-think, conceive, and re-conceive, the way in which we understand history of a culture? Do the visual materials— be that paintings, photographs, or films—demand from us to re-think history? Or are we to simply treat the visual materials as yet another objects of our cultural past that can simply be folded into the discursive mechanism that we have come to know as history? The question here is not simply on how we are to carry out a(ny) history of visual cultures of India, but more crucially, it simultaneously is the question over our understanding of the category of ‘History’ itself as it gets read and interrupted by the ‘Visual.’

In this introductory course, we will read, and more importantly, *look at* the visual culture(s) of the Indian subcontinent through the 18th to 21st centuries. From early-modern paintings produced during the late Medieval/pre-modern period of India as it existed under the Mughal empire [18th century], to the photo-images captured during the reign of British empire [19th and 20th century], and finally to the moving-image culture of the Post-Colonial India [20th and 21st century], the current course seeks to provide a historical and historicist understanding of India primarily via the changing landscape of its visual culture(s). Throughout this course, we will i) understand the changing landscapes of visual cultures of India, ii) interrogate transitions, continuities, and ruptures, amongst various image-making practises throughout the Indian visual history, and iii) attempt to understand the history or histories to which the visual objects bear witness. Finally, amidst ‘Visual’ and the ‘H/historical,’ if there is a question which this survey course asks, it is this: What happens to our understanding of History as it gets read, represented, and re-presented, through the Visual (-medium)?

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Assignments:

Active Participation (15%)

While your regular attendance in class is a primary requirement for you to succeed in this class, solely being physically present is by no means enough. It is required that i) you come to class having finished your weekly readings, ii) pay close attention to what is being taught by the instructor, and iii) fully participate during our in-class discussions.

Weekly Posts (15%)

I will pose a question at the end of our class every week, which would directly be related to our reading materials and our lecture content. You are expected to write a brief response to the question (250 words) and post it on our Blackboard (under ‘Weekly Discussion Posts’ page). These brief weekly posts are

¹ Popular Hindi proverb which can be translated loosely in English as: “[May-] No evil eye gets onto you.” While the use of this Hindi proverb falls into the domain of sentences enunciated to avoid bringing misfortune upon oneself [“Knock Wood”], the primary focus of the proverb remains over the thematic of ‘vision’ and ‘eye.’ It is widely believed, especially in Hindi speaking parts of India, that one can ‘get’ someone’s ‘evil eye’ onto them. A subtle but forceful system of ‘vision’ and ‘visuality’ is assumed to be operational within the social field. A system that can prove to be ruinous to oneself.

designed to test your general comprehension about the material while fostering you to develop a critical writing and readings skills.

Midterm Paper (25%)

You will choose a tradition of Painting from pre-colonial India or a Photographer from the British Empire and will write a 6-page paper tracing its history. Some of the questions you are required to respond in your paper are: i) Where, When, and How, does the tradition or photographer emerge? ii) What cultural aspects does the tradition, or the photographer, engage with in their work? and finally iii) What does their work tell us about the Historical time period within which they were working? It is required that you consult with your TA before deciding upon a theme or a photographer

Final Exam (25%)

This take-home exam is divided in two sections:

Section-I is designed to test your knowledge about the reading materials [Short Answer Questions]

Section-II will test on your ability to creatively read and argue over themes of 'Visual Culture' and 'History' that we have engaged with throughout the semester.

Discussion Sessions (20%)

Refer to your Discussion Session Syllabus for details for details

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Course Schedule:**Week: 1 | Visual Studies in South Asia: An Introduction**

- 'Mapping Visual Cultures in South Asia,' *India and its Visual Cultures*, Uwe Skoda and Birgit Lettmann
- 'Vernacular Visual: Seeing in South Asia,' *Seeing South Asia: Visuals Beyond Borders*, S Jha
- 'Visual Culture and the Meanings of Culture,' *Exploring Culture: Definitions, Concepts, Contexts*, Matthew Rampley

Weekly Images:

- Digital Libraries: [Furer-Haimendorff Collection](#), [Mary Binney Wheeler Image Collection](#), [Indian Collection at British Library](#)

Week: 2 | Before the British: Paintings in Mughal India

- "Act of Viewing: Looking at Paintings in the Indian Context," B N Goswamy
- *The Visual World of Muslim India: The Art, Culture, and Society of the Deccan in the Early Modern Era*, Laura Parodi and Richard M. Eaton, ed.

Weekly Images:

- Paintings from Mughal India, Andrew Topsfield
- Mughal Painting Through Ages, Anurag Mathur

Commented [NP1]: What is 'Visual Study'? And what is it that we do when we do a visual study of an area like that of South Asia? These basic yet essential questions will form the basis of the first lecture. While Skoda and Birgit will help students in charting the visual cultures of South Asia, Jha will help in thinking about the question of 'vernacular' [i.e., if there is anything in SA's visual culture that is particular to the place]. Finally, Rampley will help in thinking particularly about 'Culture(s)' within Visual Culture.

Commented [NP2]: The second week begins with thinking about visual culture via paintings of Mughal India. Here, while Goswamy's text help, theoretically speaking, situate the task of 'viewing' paintings within the Indian context, Parodi and Eaton edited volume will help with looking at particular case studies of the Mughal Paintings.

Week: 3 | Princes, Painters, and their Paintings

- *Painters and Princes in Mughal Delhi, 1707-1857*, William Dalrymple and Yuthika Sharma, eds.
- *Real Birds in Imagined Gardens: Mughal Painting Between Persia and Europe*, Kavita Singh

Weekly Images:

- The Imperial Image: Paintings from the Mughal Court, Milo Beach
- The Emperors Album, The MET Publication
- The Art of Mughal India: Painting and Precious Objects, Asia Society

Commented [NP3]: The third week continues with the Mughal paintings. However, this week, with Dalrymple and Sharma's text, we will be focusing on the relationship between the art-making practice of Mughal Delhi, especially the paintings produced by Mughal Prince. Singh's text, on the other hand, will open up the question of the transnational circulation of paintings between Persia and Europe.

Week: 4 | On the Verge of an(other) Empire: Trajectories and Connections

- *Room for Wonder: Indian Painting During the British Period, 1760-1880*, Stuart Cary Welch
- *Company Painting: Indian Paintings of the British Period*, V&A, London, Mildred Archer
- [*Mimesis Across Empire: Artworks and Networks in India 1765-1860*, Natasha Eaton]

Weekly Images:

- Forgotten Masters: Indian Painting for the East India Company, Dalrymple
- Portraits and Types Reinscribing Forms in Nineteenth Century India and Europe Holly Shaffer

Commented [NP4]: The fourth week works as a transition between the Mughal Empire and then emerging Company Rule of the British East India Company. While still being situated within paintings, Welch's essay thinks about Painting as an object in transition between the Mughal Empire and the East India Company. Mildred Archer's text will further help us with thinking about Company Paintings made by Indian artists and representing the British.

Week: 5 | Enter the Englishmen: Introduction of/to Photo-Images in Colonial India

- 'Sepai Mutiny Colonial Photography and its Other in India,' Christopher Pinney
- 'Photography as Cure,' *Coming of Photography in India*, Christopher Pinney
- [*Photography in the 19th century India*, Shivani Sud]

Weekly Images:

- Encountering India: Colonial Photography, 1850-1911, Museum of Sydney
- Under Indian Skies: 19th century photographs from a private collection, John falconer
- [Old Indian Photos](#)

Commented [NP5]: The transitions we have been tracing between the Mughal empire and the British rule in terms of paintings finally becomes a transition in terms of the visual medium. We shift from Paintings to Photographs and shift from the Mughal Empire to the British Empire. With Pinney's essay on Sepai/Sepoy Mutiny of 1857, a mutiny that resulted in the establishment of the crown within the Indian subcontinent, we will start thinking about the photographs as visual objects. Moreover, Pinney, via the chapter 'Photography as cure,' would also inform us about the coming of photography in India, while also helping us to think about the impacts/effects of the introduction of photography in the subcontinent.

Week: 6 | Colonial Images as Means of Knowledge:

- 'Exploring Darkness,' and 'Framing the View,' *Picturing Empire: Photography and Visualization of the British Empire*, James Ryan
- 'The Laboratory of Mankind': John McCosh and the Beginning of Photography in British India, Ray McKenzie
- Archives and Origins: The Material and Vernacular Cultures of Photography in India, Sudhir Mahadevan

Weekly Images:

- [Photographs of Western India: Vol 1 \[Costume and Characters\]](#)

Commented [NP6]: Week six is the first of the four-week series where we think about colonial photographic images in their operation within various socio-cultural registers. Within this week, we will think about the question of (colonial-)knowledge via photographic images, beginning with James Ryan who help us think about the question of colonial illegibility and how photography comes in and illuminates the colonial world by framing it in a particular manner. McKenzie's article is situated within British India, and by taking the case study of John McCosh, helps us think about the deployment of photography as means of creating knowledge within the colony.

Week: 7 | Colonial Images as Tool of Power: Durbars and the Police

- 'Composing the spectacle: colonial portraiture and the coronation durbars of British india, 1877-1911,' S Willcock
- 'Power and Resistance: The Delhi Coronation Durbar,' Julie Codell
- 'Visualizing Order: Photography and the Production of Colonial Police in India,' MR Waits
- 'Capturing Bisra Munda: The Virtuality of a Colonial Era Photograph,' D Rycroft

Weekly Images:

- Bourne and Shepherd's Royal Photographic Album connected with H.H.H. the Prince of Wales Tour in India, 1876

Commented [NP7]: Week seven, the second of the four-week series, will open up the question of the representation of power via images. Divided between thinking about Police and thinking about the royal Durbars, this week poses the question of how power was visualized and disseminated? While Willcock's articles chart images of Durbars held between 1877 and 1911, and thinks about them as a site of spectacles, Codell focuses on Delhi Coronation Durbar, the only Durbar that George V attended. Beyond Durbars, Waits' article helps us think about how Police were 'represented,' while Rycroft help us think about photography's use in the case of capturing Bisra Munda (an anti-colonial fighter).

Week: 8 | Colonial Images as Language of Representation: Subaltern, Caste, Anthropology

- 'The Construction and Institutionalisation of Ethnicity: Anthropology, Photography and the Nagas', D Das
- 'Classification and Fantasy in Photographic Construction of Caste and Tribe,' C Pinney
- 'Adivasi Images, Adivasi Voices: The Resonance of Eicksted Collection,' Katja Muller
- ['Colonial India's fanatical fakirs and their popular representation,' Rianne Siebenga]

Weekly Images:

- The People of India: A Series of Photographic Illustrations with Descriptive Letterpress, Vol. 1, The Races and Tribes of Hindustan
- [The Oriental Races and Tribes, William Johnson](#)

Commented [NP8]: Week eight, the third of the four-week series, thinks about the question of representing the colonial subject. This, I think, is one of the important weeks because it brings into spotlight the two big themes within colonial and post-colonial studies: 'subjectivity' and the question of 'representation.' While Das' article on Photography and Anthropology of Nagas (indigenous tribes) engages with how photography was used to produce anthropological knowledge, Pinney's article, in a certain sense, extends Das' argument by showing how it was that classification amongst Tribe and Caste was undertaken via images. Finally, Muller provides yet another view on the themes of Anthropology and Photography within colonial India (this time via images of Adivasi taken by a German Anthropologist).

Week: 9 | Colonial Images as Site of Imagination: Capitalism, Nationalism, Politics

- 'Caricature in Print Media: A History of Study of Political Cartoons in Colonial India,' D Bhattacharya
- 'Brand-Name Capitalism and Professional Advertising in India,' *The Emergence of Brand-Name Capitalism in Late Colonial India*, Douglas Haynes
- 'Visually Mapping the "nation" Swadeshi politics in nationalist India, 1920-1930,' LN Trivedi

Weekly Images:

- The Goddess and Nation, Sumathi Ramaswamy (Images)
- Gods in Bazaar: The Economies of Indian Calendar Art, Kajri Jain (Images)

Commented [NP9]: Week nine, the final week of the series, shift from the images that are 'governmental' (made for the purpose of imperial governance) and brings the discussion to the popular culture [Advertisement, Anti-British protests and Nationalism, etc.]. While Haynes' article opens up the theme of both advertisement and brand-name capitalism in colonial India, Bhattacharya and Trivedi bring in the themes of popular politics via caricature and the theme of visually mapping the nation, respectively.

Week: 10 | Empire's Ending(s): Towards New World, Towards Moving Images

- *Colonial India and the Making of Empire Cinema: Image, Ideology, Identity*, P Chowdhry
- *Cinema at the End of Empire*, Priya Jaikumar

Weekly Moving-Images:

- The Drum (1938), Dir. Zolton Korda
- *Outside Lettered City: Cinema, Modernity, and Public Sphere in Late Colonial India*, M Dass

Commented [NP10]: This week is the last week of the British colonial empire. It initiates a transition to post-colonial India by transitioning towards the technologies of moving images. While Chowdhry's text will help us think about what she terms as 'empire cinema' [cinema made in Hollywood and Britain, depicting the colonial world and during the turbulent years of 1930s and 1940s,], Jaikumar, especially with her close reading of genre of movies made during late colonial India, will help us situate and think/read/see closely the movies produced towards the end of the British empire.

Week: 11 | Exit Empire: Moving Images in World of Transition(s)

- *Mourning the Nation: Indian Cinema in the Wake of Partition*, Bhaskar Sarkar
- *National Identity in Popular Cinema, 1947-1987*, Sumita Chakravarty

Weekly Images:

- In the Language of Remembering: The Inheritance of Partition, Aanchal Malhotra
- Remnants of a Separation: A History of Partition Through Material Objects, Aanchal Malhotra
- In the Shadow of Raj, Derry Moore

Commented [NP11]: As a twin to the previous week (where we thought about cinema at the end of the empire), we continue our engagement with cinema; but this week, we focus on cinema as it existed on the other side of 1947 (i.e., cinema of post-partition Independent India). How do the themes of a newly independent country, a country which has also gone through a violent process of partition, get visualized and represented within cinema? We will consider this question via texts by Bhaskar Sarkar and Sumita Chakravarty. Sarkar's text will help us think about the violence of partition, while Chakravarty's text will help us think about the theme of the formation of national identity.

Week: 12 | Young Nation, Old Images: TV Serials and Popular (Re-)Publics

- *Image Journeys: Audio-Visual Media and Cultural Change in India*, Christina Brosius and Melissa Butcher (Ed.)
- *Pleasure and the Nation: The History, Politics and Consumption of Public Culture in India*, Christopher Pinney and Rachel Dwyer (Ed.)

Weekly Moving-Images:

- Ramayana (TV Series, 1987-88), Dir. Ramanand Sagar
- Artisan Camera: Studio Photography from Central India, Pinney

Commented [NP12]: Week twelve brings to the forefront the question/theme of popular within post-colonial India. With Pinney and Dwyer, we think about politics, consumption, and politics of consumption in India as it undergoes its neo-liberalization. While with Brosius and Butcher, we will think about popular media (TV programs and popular entertainment will be spotlighted during our conversation)

Week: 13 | Visual Cultures of 21st Century: Publics, Production, and Crisis

- *Producing Bollywood: Inside the Contemporary Hindi Film*, Tejaswini Ganti
- *Bollywood's India: Hindi Cinema as a Guide to Contemporary India*, Rachel Dwyer
[*The Melodramatic Public: Film Forum and Spectatorship in Indian Cinema*, Ravi Vasudevan]

Weekly Moving-Images:

- A Night of Remembering Nothing (2021), Dir. Payal Kapadia
- Postdate: Photography and Inherited History in India, San Jose Museum of Art

Commented [NP13]: The final week of the course brings the students to the current and pressing issues of India in 21st century via understanding Bollywood. With Ganti's text, we will chart how Bollywood, a powerhouse of Indian film industry, got 'produced' (i.e., how a Mumbai-based film industry produced its own identity through moving-image production). Rachel Dwyer will help us end the course by helping us think about 21st century 'India' as it gets mediated via the image-producing machine that is Bollywood. Just like the beginning, we will end by coming back to the question of how the 'visual' help us understand the culture within which it emerges?

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